Perhaps that was one of the problems for us in that tournament: we spent too much time ‘preparing’. The Caribbean is a fantastic place to tour – it’s beautiful, with a very chilled-out atmosphere, and you’ve got plenty of South African supporters around. Understandably, the guys in the team were enjoying themselves. I wouldn’t say more drinking than usual was going on, but the guys certainly put back a beverage or two.

That said, the training in those two weeks went really well. The guys were sharp in the warm-up games and all seemed fine. In the group games we thumped everyone, until we got to our nemesis, the Aussies. Clearly looking for some revenge after losing the 438 game, they came out guns blazing and klapped 377, with Matthew Hayden in a particularly vicious mood, hitting 101 off 68 balls. There were some wide-eyed Proteas bowlers that day. We managed 294 in reply.

A couple of the guys had been cramping during the group games, and the press and fans speculated that we were both unfit and overweight. *Sports Illustrated* South Africa published some images of the guys with their kit off playing volleyball and lounging around the pool during some time off, and the shots weren’t very flattering. Maybe the photographer had used a wide-angle lens; I don’t know. Anyway, the okes in the pictures – Smithy, Kallis, Boucher and Justin Kemp – were really pissed off about the article.

To be honest, I think the fact that they weren’t drinking enough fluids to compensate for the heat was the cause of the cramping rather than them being unfit and/or overweight. Some of the guys might not exactly have been lean, but they always passed the fitness bleep tests we were all put through (more about those tests later).

Anyway, so we qualified for the Super Eight phase, where we started blowing a little hot and cold. We beat Sri Lanka – very satisfying after 2003 – Ireland and the West Indies, and we creamed England. But then we lost to New Zealand and suffered a shock defeat against Bangladesh, where I was the only player for South Africa to score any meaningful runs. I got 56 not out in a team total of 184, chasing Bangladesh’s 251. Still … at least we had made the semis. Problem was, we were up against the Aussies again.

The night before the semi-final, we were just trying to be really calm about the whole thing. We had done our analyses and had studied all their strengths and weaknesses. We now had a game plan for how we were going to bowl to each Aussie batsman. We even had separate meetings for the batters and the bowlers. At the batting meeting, as far as I was concerned,